

Stuart's finest moment came at Chancellorsville, when command of the army's Second Corps devolved upon him after Stonewall Jackson's mortal wounding. The cavalryman handled the infantry brilliantly, leading thousands of foot soldiers through thick brush and heading several of the charges that broke the Union back. On June 9, 1863, Stuart was hit by a surprise Union attack at Brandy Station, Virginia. In the largest cavalry clash of the war, Stuart's men just managed to fend off the Union horsemen, but it was a bloody affair. Annoyed, Stuart mounted an audacious cavalry raid across the Potomac; he captured numerous supply wagons, but lost touch with Lee, then on his second invasion of the North. Temporarily deprived of his "eyes and ears," Lee stumbled into a battle not of his choosing at Gettysburg.

At Spotsylvania Court House, Stuart practically saved Lee's army, when his troopers held up General Grant's oncoming Union juggernaut long enough for Stuart to herd the arriving Confederate soldiers into battle lines west of the village. He might indeed have made a superb corps commander of infantry, but never got the chance.

Only days after the outbreak of fighting at Spotsylvania, Stuart and his outnumbered horsemen were battling Sheridan's troopers at Yellow Tavern outside Richmond. As Stuart galloped into the thick of the fight, his bugler remarked, "General, I believe you love bullets." Stuart merely replied, "I don't reckon there is any danger." Moments later, a retreating Michigan private took a parting shot at a figure in gray who had been emptying his pistol at them. Stuart spun in his saddle.

He was removed to his brother-in-law's house in Richmond, where he died 24 hours later. As his funeral cortege wound through the city's streets, there was no music and no pageantry, only the muffled roar of cannons as the fighting raged on outside the capital.